

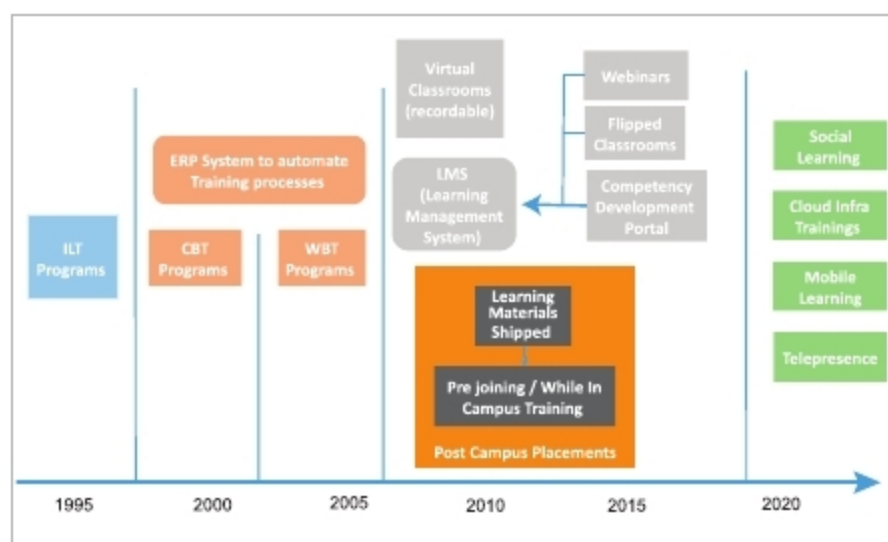


Figure 1: Adoption of e-learning in an IT company, over a period of time

Business triggers for e-learning adoption

In a small IT business with a few hundred employees, the competency-building function will perhaps be less organised, with employees often learning by themselves and on the job. Such a business specialises in a few skills and is often happy to hire fresh talent from the market on a need basis. The situation changes when rapid growth happens, with many projects flowing into the business and it needing to scale quickly.

When teams are small and the company is also of a modest size, the training needs are few and far between. And when there is a need, the people available to train and get trained are limited too. Training, in such situations, often happens out of regular business hours, to ensure service continuity for customers. However, when such a business grows and new IT projects flow in, the need for re-skilling existing employees arises in the system. The business trains competent and proven professionals in new technology platforms and then deploys them in new projects. Investments are made for these professionals and training gets done during the business hours. These investments are often routed through a dedicated technical competency management function, which is a part of human resources. In the early years, such technical training was predominantly led by instructors and conducted in a classroom. The classrooms were few and the number of programmes were also not many.

The early adoption of e-learning was through computer based training (CBT). This was early e-learning software, designed and delivered through CDs. The courses were quite effective in the areas of management, team building, communication and other behavioural skills. They were installed in a set of demarcated machines meant for CBT learning, or put into circulation for employees to use the software and return it to a central library. These courses were successful in engaging employees and empowering them to learn by themselves. Much of the CBT had intermediate quizzes and assessments to evaluate the lessons learnt by the users. CBTs were not a very scalable and manageable solution for a growing business. However, at the right time, the Internet came to the rescue.

With Web/Internet applications evolving in the late 90s, the CBT was replaced with e-learning material that was deployable and accessible online. Many WBT (Web based training) vendors came onto the scene offering the courses for a fee based on the licensing model for corporates. Many relevant courses were purchased and made available in a secured manner for professionals to access. These were better for scalability when compared to a CBT. Availability to users was high as they got served over the Internet and with much better ease of access. All you needed was a computer browser and the Internet to access the materials. The investments in WBT were relatively higher and it was not easy to track the usage of the material. Few vendors did provide limited reports to get some sense of the return on such investments. In spite of this shortcoming, WBT was a great step to enable professionals to learn from anywhere and anytime. The period during which they were not on projects and were unable to find an ILT (instructor-led training) programme to attend, could now be meaningfully spent to gain new skills, right from their desks.

The WBT was weak on assessments and also did not support integrated assessments, progress tracking and a certification process. The courses were also limited to the content provided or hosted by the vendors. One could not host content built in-house. The next stage on the e-learning journey for any business then was to have its own, custom LMS (learning management system).

It all started with ILT and the adoption of CBT on desktops. With the growth of Web and Internet technologies, CBT was replaced with WBT modules hosted by vendors. Successful adoption of WBT then set the stage for LMS and many learning initiatives. Future adoption trends indicate cloud based sophisticated systems that provide virtual training environments, e-learning delivered on mobiles, tele-presence and social learning.

Managed e-learning through LMS

The design and implementation of an LMS is the next step in this journey. There are open source LMSs like Moodle and COTS (commercial off-the-shelf) products like SumTotal (<http://www.sumtotalsystems.com/>) and SABA (<https://www.saba.com/us/>) available for enterprises. Customised COTS products provide a very scalable, stable and accessible e-learning delivery platform at the enterprise level. They are integrated with systems that manage the training operations, performance measurements (used by the human resources team) and many other supply chain software systems. Such an integrated platform provides a unified experience to employees of several key HR processes, like employee development plans, mandatory training and compliance training. It also cuts down the time to roll out central competency initiatives (applicable to anyone in the company) in large organisations. This is often done by HR teams in collaboration with the competency development function.